2014

Michael Clarke brought his Australia team on tour for three Tests in February and March and we looked forward to what was another opportunity to end the jinx and win a home series against Australia.

Mitchell Johnson revelled in the conditions at the first Test in Centurion, bowling with rib-pummelling pace and fine control, and, while I was pleased to reach 91 in difficult conditions, we were dismissed for 206 in the first innings and then bowled out for 200 in the second innings. We were well beaten.

Another great fast bowler dominated the second Test at St George's Park in Port Elizabeth. After JP and I scored centuries, helping us reach 423 in our first innings, the Australians were eventually set a target of 448 runs to win, with two days left to play. We seemed in a dominant position, but Chris Rogers and David Warner took their opening stand into three figures and, with rain forecast on the last day, we were running out of time.

In our time of need, Dale produced a remarkable spell of reverse swing, taking three wickets for 11 runs in five overs, dismissing Michael Clarke, Steve Smith and Brad Haddin. The Australians collapsed from 126 without loss to 216 all out, and we duly secured victory by 231 runs, levelling the series at 1–1.

Australia won an important toss in the deciding Test at Newlands, and big centuries from both Warner and Clarke enabled them to declare their first innings at 494 for seven. We were batting under scoreboard pressure. Sensing weakness, Johnson and Harris were storming in. We managed only 287 in reply, and when they reached 22 without loss at stumps on the third day, the tourists appeared to be taking control.

'Guys, can you gather around?' Graeme asked quietly.

Players were packing away their kit in the dressing room, and I remember sensing that this was not going to be the usual captain's pep talk at the end of what had been a demanding day.